Objectification theory: Toward understanding women's lived experiences and mental health risks

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(ENGLISH)

This article offers objectification theory as a framework for understanding the experiential consequences of being female in a culture that sexually objectifies the female body. Objectification theory posits that girls and women are typically acculturated to internalize an observer's perspective as a primary view of their physical selves. This perspective on self can lead to habitual body monitoring, which, in turn, can increase women's opportunities for shame and anxiety, reduce opportunities for peak motivational states, and diminish awareness of internal bodily states. Accumulations of such experiences may help account for an array of mental health risks that disproportionately affect women: unipolar depression, sexual dysfunction, and eating disorders. Objectification theory also illuminates why changes in these mental health risks appear to occur in step with life-course changes in the female body. (PsycInfo Database Record (c) 2024 APA, all rights reserved) (Source: journal abstract)

:	At Risk Populations (主要); Human Females (主要); Life Experiences (主要); Mental Disorders (主要); Self-Concept (主要); Lived Experience (主要); Physical Appearance; Psychosexual Behavior; Theories; Objectification; Health Risk Behavior
:	3210: Psychological Disorders
:	Childhood (birth-12 yrs); Adulthood (18 yrs & older)
:	Human; Female
():	objectification theory of internalizing observers' perspective as primary view of physical self, understanding lived experiences & mental health risks, human females
:	Objectification theory: Toward understanding women's lived experiences and mental health risks
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:	Psychology of Women Quarterly
:	Psychol Women Q
:	21
:	2

:	173
:	206
:	Jun 1997
:	Print
:	Blackwell Publishing (United Kingdom)
:	Sage Publications (US); Wiley-Blackwell Publishing Ltd. (United Kingdom)
/:	United Kingdom
ISSN:	0361-6843
eISSN:	1471-6402
:	是
:	英语
:	Journal, Peer Reviewed Journal, Journal Article
DOI:	https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1471-6402.1997.tb00108.x
:	01 1 月 1997 (PsycINFO)
:	11 Nov 2024 (PsycINFO)
:	1997-04768-001
ProQuest ID:	619078997
URL:	https://www.proquest.com/scholarly-journals/objectification-theory-toward-understanding/docview/619078997/se-2?accountid=211388
:	APA PsycInfo®

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